



Govspeak guide

What is Govspeak?

Govspeak (<https://github.com/alphagov/govspeak>) is a simplified version of [Markdown](http://daringfireball.net/projects/markdown/syntax) (<http://daringfireball.net/projects/markdown/syntax>) used on [GOV.UK](https://www.gov.uk/) (<https://www.gov.uk/>). It's designed to be as easy-to-read and easy-to-write as possible, using simple punctuation instead of complicated tags and code.

Govspeak was developed by the [Government Digital Service](https://gds.blog.gov.uk) (<https://gds.blog.gov.uk>) with some extra features that we use to format content on [GOV.UK](https://www.gov.uk/) (<https://www.gov.uk/>).

This guide is for Mainstream publisher Govspeak. View the [Govspeak guide for Whitehall publisher](https://www.gov.uk/guidance/how-to-publish-on-gov-uk/markdown) (<https://www.gov.uk/guidance/how-to-publish-on-gov-uk/markdown>).

Acronyms

List these in the following format at the end of the document and all occurrences will be marked up as acronyms:

govspeak

*[FCD0]: Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office

This means the full text will appear when users hover over the acronym wherever it occurs on the page.

If you use the acronym in singular and plural in your content, always put the plural one first in the list.

govspeak

***[PCSOs]: Police Community Support
Officers**
***[PCSO]: Police Community Support Officer**

Addresses

govspeak

\$A
**HM Revenue and
Customs**
Bradford
BD98 1YY
\$A

This creates an address box, which looks like this:

HM Revenue and Customs
Bradford
BD98 1YY

Do not use bold for the address title. This is not accessible because it looks like a heading and can be confusing for users of assistive technology. Use heading Markdown above the address Markdown instead if you need to draw attention to the information.

Bold text

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****Double asterisks around text** will turn it bold.
Use it sparingly.**

This is what it looks like:

Double asterisks around text will turn it bold. Use it sparingly.

Bulleted lists

Unordered lists

Create bulleted lists using asterisks, hyphens or plus signs at the start of each line:

```
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```

```
* asterisk 1
* asterisk 2
* asterisk 3

- a hyphen
- another hyphen

+ plus signs
+ more plus
signs
```

This is what they look like:

- asterisk 1
- asterisk 2
- asterisk 3

Ordered lists (steps)

We only use numbered lists for describing steps as part of a process. Do this by adding:

```
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```

```
s1. Add numbers.
s2. Check numbers.
s3. Love numbers.
```

This example follows the [style guide](https://www.gov.uk/guidance/style-guide/a-to-) (<https://www.gov.uk/guidance/style-guide/a-to->

[z-of-gov-uk-style#steps](#)) and looks like:

- 1 Add numbers.
- 2 Check numbers.
- 3 Love numbers.

Steps need an extra line break after the final step (in other words, 2 full blank lines). If you don't do this, other Markdown directly after them won't work. If you have a subheading after numbered steps, add a line break after this.

Buttons

Default button

```
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```

```
{button}[Continue](https://gov.uk/random){/  
button}
```

which looks like this:

Continue

Start now button

To turn a button into a '[Start now](https://www.gov.uk/service-manual/design/start-pages#start-page-elements)' button (<https://www.gov.uk/service-manual/design/start-pages#start-page-elements>), you can add **start** to the button tag.

These buttons should only appear once per page, and be used at the start of a transaction.

```
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```

```
{button start}[Start now](https://gov.uk/random){/  
button}
```

which looks like this:

Start now

Cross domain tracking button

You can add a Google Analytics [tracking id \(https://support.google.com/analytics/answer/7372977?hl=en\)](https://support.google.com/analytics/answer/7372977?hl=en) which will send page views to another domain, this is used to help services understand the start of their users journeys.

```
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```

```
{button start cross-domain-tracking:UA-XXXXXX-Y}  
[Start now](https://example.com/external-service/  
start-now)  
{/button}
```

which looks like this:

Start now

Callouts

To draw attention to content, you can use callouts. For example, you can put some text in an ‘information callout’ to indicate that it’s something related that’s worth knowing, or does not fit the flow of the content.

Only use the more severe ‘warning callout’ to indicate serious consequences, such as a fine or criminal proceedings.

Information callouts

```
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```

```
^This is useful information that's worth  
knowing.^
```

This looks like:

This is useful information that's worth knowing.

Warning callouts

```
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```

```
%You will be fined or put in prison if you don't do  
this thing.%
```

This looks like:

! You will be fined or put in prison if you don't do this thing.

Example callout

Use the appropriate heading Markdown above the example Markdown if you need to draw attention to the information.

```
govspeak
```

```
$E  
Open the pod bay  
doors.  
$E
```

This looks like:

Open the pod bay doors.

Contacts

```
govspeak
```

```
$C
```

```
Financial Conduct Authority
```

```
<consumer.queries@fca.org.uk>
```

```
Telephone: 0800 111 6768
```

```
Monday to Friday, 8am to 6pm
```

```
Saturday, 9am to 1pm
```

```
[Find out about call charges](/call-  
charges)
```

```
$C
```

Remember to add a call charges link when there are telephone numbers.

This creates a contact box, which looks like this:

Financial Conduct Authority

consumer.queries@fca.org.uk

Telephone: 0800 111 6768

Monday to Friday, 8am to 6pm

Saturday, 9am to 1pm

[Find out about call charges \(/call-charges\)](/call-charges)

Do not use bold for the contact team name. This is not accessible because it looks like a heading and can be confusing for users of assistive technology. Use heading Markdown above the contact Markdown instead if you need to draw attention to the information.

Download links

Use '\$D' to place download links in a box that shows users they're going to download a file. Always include the file type and size in brackets as part of the link text and title.